DAAT TEVUNOT: THE RAMHAL ON CREATION, GOOD AND EVIL, AND THE SOUL

Could Adam Have Fixed the World in One Day?

Daat Tevunot §40

Sefer: Daat Tevunot by Rabbi Moshe Hayim Luzzatto (the Ramhal) **Sections:** §40 (continued)
Shiur: Part of Dayan Daniel Kada's series on Daat Tevunot, Monday 14 November 2022

These notes are based on an automatic transcript of the recording.

Where we are

This class continues the long §40, the section the English edition calls "How God's revelation can be brought about in two different ways." The summary so far: God created the world to bestow good, and does it through yihud Hashem. Yihud Hashem allows evil and deficiency to exist so that human effort can repair them. Because evil is only temporary, it must end, and free will ends with it. The unity can be revealed in two ways: by God doing it, or, better, by us doing it, by rejecting the bad.

We can do it ourselves

The Ramhal says that human beings could do it all themselves: recognise the truth and leave the vanities and falsehoods of this world to come closer to God. That means recognising that whatever God commanded us not to do belongs to the category of bad, and that bad exists only through God's concealment. God is good and cannot create bad; He can conceal Himself and allow a vacuum in which evil exists. If we recognise that every temptation is a manifestation of that concealment, we reject the deceit of our eyes and choose God's light. Then His unity would be revealed by itself, and there would be no need for the length of the exile. Everything bad exists only to instil this recognition in us, so that in the world to come we can delight in His unity.

Last week the Ramhal said that the darker things get, the greater the revelation. That is true, the Rabbi said, as the more darkness you have been in, the more you appreciate the light. But do not conclude that we must go through the darkness. That idea is very dangerous. After Shabbetai Sevi, his followers committed the most terrible sins, claiming they were descending to the depths to raise the sparks as part of the tikkun. "Messianic ideas can be very, very dangerous." The point is the opposite: we have the ability to hasten it.

Two kinds of test

- **Temptation:** take non-kosher food that looks very tempting. My body wants it. Eating it says: although God said this is bad, it is good and tasty. That is failing to recognise His unity. Every temptation looks good but does not end up being good.

- **Disasters:** when terrible things happen, of course nature is involved, but is it merely nature, or is there a message? Do we start to think the world is random and runs by itself?

Rejecting evil in both areas affirms yihud Hashem, and then we will not need the length of the exile.

Is evil created?

A participant challenged the idea that evil is not God's creation: evil acts and evil beings exist, so who created them? The discussion went back and forth: - The Rabbi cited "yoser or uvore hoshekh," He forms light and creates darkness: evil comes about through God withdrawing, which allows it to exist and develop. - Another participant pointed out that everything, including the good and human beings, exists only through simsum. The Rabbi agreed that this was an excellent question and explained from the opening of the Ari's Ets Hayim: after God withdrew, He funnelled His light back in. That light allows the good and human beings to exist. Where the light is not found there is complete darkness, which allows bad to develop of its own accord. - The participant said it seemed dangerous to say something comes into being not created by Hashem. A third suggested thinking of a force, like an angel with a job, whose task of tempting grows stronger when light withdraws and is pushed aside when we do good. Another proposed that it is not plus and minus but a scale from 0 to infinity, with every test asking whether we face towards God or away, so that everything, including what we call evil, is from Hashem as a test.

The Rabbi said he needed to think about it further and look at Derech Hashem again, though he still held his explanation. Later in the class a participant noted that the English translation itself says Adam realised "all evil was created by God only as a means to reveal His glory," and the Rabbi asked what "created" means here, perhaps "allowed to exist," and left the point for another time.

Adam: a case study

The Ramhal now applies this to Adam. Had God created the world with only good, humanity could not even conceive of bad, nor understand yihud Hashem, which is known through negating bad. Because He wanted His unity revealed, He created bad, and so humanity can think about bad or, alternatively, recognise the unity.

Adam saw the possibility of evil in the Tree of Knowledge and his eyes tricked him: the tree was good to eat, a delight to the eyes, and desirable for wisdom. He thought there might be two powers. If he had truly believed that nothing exists outside God's will, he would have reasoned: God told me not to eat it, so I cannot gain anything from it. Looks nice? Tastes good? Impossible.

The Ramhal continues: Adam was truly a great hakham and should have known through his wisdom that anything that appears contrary to what God said is only a facade, vanity and falsehood, part of the evil God made to reveal His oneness and to test us so that we gain merit. Had he withstood the test and not been enticed by the serpent, he would have achieved the unity. The test was on Friday, and in one day he would have done what will now take 6,000 years. Hashem would have shown that what he believed was true, and all evil would have ceased. "How utopian, how beautiful. This is what should have been."

The Rabbi again noted that Adam HaRishon is not one person like you and me: the Torah says "HaAdam," the entity, the human species.

Why we deny God

A participant found it strange that Adam was effectively denying God's oneness. The Rabbi pointed to the next lines: once enticed by desire, a person has to invent all kinds of leniencies to justify himself. That is why people deny God: so they can do what they want. He read from Aldous Huxley: "I had motives for not wanting the world to have a meaning; consequently assumed that it had none... For myself, as no doubt for most of my friends, the philosophy of meaninglessness was essentially an instrument of liberation from a certain system of morality. We objected to the morality because it interfered with our sexual freedom."

Another participant recalled being taught that Adam ate to make his test harder and so gain more. The Rabbi called that "a nice derush," but not the simple meaning. The Hakhamim say Adam was a min, a heretic, as the Ramhal will show next week. In truth every time we sin we are heretics, which is why we need constant reminders of yihud Hashem: Shema Yisrael so many times a day, the mezuzah going in and out, tefillin and sisit on us.

Summary

- Humanity could reveal God's unity itself by seeing every forbidden thing as a facade born of His concealment, and then the long exile would be unnecessary.
- The idea that darkness brings greater light must never become a reason to sin, as Shabbetai Sevi's followers did.
- Whether evil is "created" was debated: it exists where God's light is withdrawn, and the Rabbi left the precise wording open.
- Adam, a great hakham, should have realised that nothing forbidden by God can benefit him; had he passed the test he would have completed in one day the work of 6,000 years.
- We deny God to free ourselves to sin, so we need constant reminders of His unity.

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